

THE SHAME WE CARRY

How Rigid Religious Sexual Ideologies Learned in Childhood Show Up in the Bedroom

Note: This presentation does not pathologize religion or spirituality. The focus is on rigid, fear-based, purity-based, or authoritarian sexual teachings and their clinical sequelae. This is not meant to be used with those who have experienced religious or cult indoctrination.

OVERVIEW

Many adults raised in sexually restrictive, religious environments present with sexual difficulties that are misattributed to low desire, relational dysfunction, or individual pathology. This workshop examines how childhood purity culture messaging becomes internalized as sexual scripts that produce shame, guilt, and embodied distress in adult sexual functioning.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- 1. Identify how rigid religious sexual ideologies become internalized sexual scripts
- 2. Recognize clinical presentations linked to purity-culture shame
- 3. Differentiate between healthy spiritual sexuality and fear-based sexual messaging
- 4. Apply trauma-informed, culturally sensitive assessment and intervention strategies
- 5. Understand the pathway from childhood teachings to adult sexual dysfunction

KEY DEFINITIONS

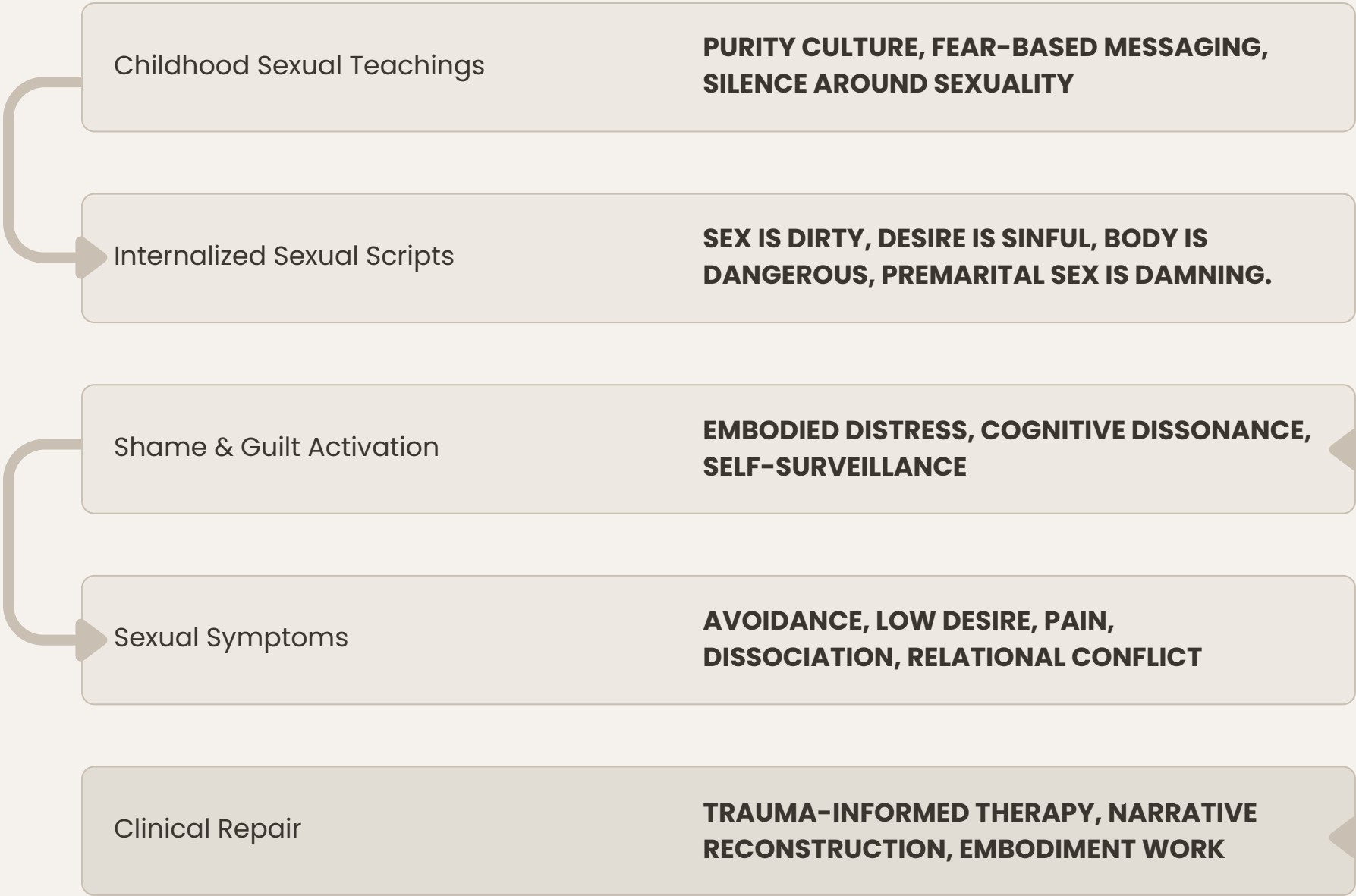
Purity Culture: A framework emphasizing sexual abstinence as moral identity, often using fear, shame, and gender-role rigidity.

Sexual Scripts: Cognitive schemas about how sexual encounters should unfold, shaped by socialization (Simon & Gagnon, 1986).

Religious Sexual Shame: Internalized belief that sexual desire, arousal, or behavior is morally contaminating.

Authoritarian Sexual Ideology: Dogmatic, non-negotiable rules about sexuality enforced through punishment or exclusion.

CLINICAL PATHWAY



CLINICAL PRESENTATION

Clients affected by rigid religious sexual ideologies may present with:

Sexual Symptoms

- » Low or absent sexual desire (often misdiagnosed as HSDD)
- » Arousal difficulties or genital pain (vaginismus, dyspareunia)
- » Dissociation during sexual activity
- » Inability to experience pleasure or orgasm
- » Compulsive sexual behavior as rebellion/shame cycle

Relational Symptoms

- » Difficulty communicating sexual needs or boundaries
- » Avoidance of physical intimacy after marriage
- » Partner conflict around sexual frequency or initiation
- » Emotional withdrawal during or after sex

Intrapsychic Symptoms

- » Persistent guilt after consensual sexual activity
- » Body shame or disgust toward genitalia
- » Cognitive dissonance between beliefs and desires
- » Identity confusion (especially for LGBTQ+ individuals)
- » Hypervigilance about sexual thoughts

ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Trauma-informed intake questions to explore religious sexual messaging:

History

- ☐ "What messages did you receive about sex, desire, or your body growing up?"
- ☐ "Where did those messages come from? What were the consequences when questioning them?"
- ☐ "How was sexuality discussed in your faith community? What was left unsaid?"
- ☐ "How do you understand the relationship between your spirituality and sexuality now?"
- ☐ "Were there consequences (spoken or unspoken) for sexual curiosity or behavior?"
- ☐ "Were purity pledges, modesty rules, or sexual gatekeeping part of your upbringing?"

Processing

- ☐ "If someone became pregnant prior to marriage, how were they treated?"
- ☐ "Do you notice any automatic thoughts or feelings during sexual situations that feel like they come from somewhere else?"
- ☐ "Has your relationship with your body or sexuality changed since leaving (or questioning) your faith tradition?"
- ☐ "Do you experience guilt, shame, or a sense of being watched during intimate moments?"

Clinical Note: Many clients have never been asked about religious sexual messaging. Normalizing the question itself can be therapeutic. Approach with curiosity, not assumption.

TREATMENT CONSIDERATIONS

Phase 1: Safety & Psychoeducation

- » Normalize the connection between religious messaging and sexual difficulty
- » Provide language for experiences (e.g., 'religious sexual shame')
- » Distinguish between spirituality and sexual ideology
- » Assess for co-occurring trauma (CSA, spiritual abuse)

Phase 2: Narrative Reconstruction

- » Externalize shame: 'Whose voice is that?'
- » Map the sexual script: origin, function, cost
- » Identify values vs. inherited rules
- » Letter-writing to younger self or faith community

Phase 3: Embodiment & Integration

- » Somatic experiencing and body-based interventions
- » Sensate focus (Masters & Johnson) adapted for shame
- » Mindfulness-based sex therapy
- » Gradual exposure to pleasure without performance

Phase 4: Relational Repair

- » Couples work: shared sexual narrative
- » Communication skills for desire discrepancy
- » Co-creating a new sexual ethic together
- » Addressing partner frustration with compassion

CULTURAL CRITIQUE

This workshop situates individual sexual distress within broader cultural systems:

Purity Culture as a System

- » Gendered: disproportionately burdens women and girls
- » Heteronormative: erases LGBTQ+ experience entirely
- » Racialized: intersects with respectability politics
- » Ableist: assumes a narrow range of 'normal' bodies

What We Are NOT Saying

- » Religion is inherently harmful
- » All religious people have sexual dysfunction
- » Clients must leave their faith to heal
- » Secular = sexually healthy

What We ARE Saying

- » Rigid, fear-based sexual ideologies cause measurable harm
- » Clinicians must assess for this etiology
- » Healing can happen within or outside faith
- » Clients deserve sexual autonomy and informed consent
- » Therapists need training in religious/sexual intersections

Recommended Frameworks: Narrative Therapy (White & Epston) | Internal Family Systems (Schwartz) | Sensate Focus (Masters & Johnson) | ACT for Sexual Concerns (Peterson) | Emotionally Focused Therapy (Johnson) | Somatic Experiencing (Levine)

CLIENT RESOURCES

BOOKS

- »» Pure: Inside the Evangelical Movement That Shamed a Generation (Klein, 2018)
- »» Shameless: A Sexual Reformation (Bolz-Weber, 2019)
- »» The Great Sex Rescue (Gregoire et al., 2021)
- »» You Are Your Own: A Reckoning with the Religious Trauma of Evangelical Christianity (Engel, 2023)
- »» Come As You Are (Nagoski, 2015)

ONLINE RESOURCES

- »» Religious Trauma Institute (religioustraumainstitute.com)
- »» Reclamation Collective (reclamationcollective.com)
- »» The Liturgists Podcast
- »» Recovering from Religion (recoveringfromreligion.org)

SUPPORT COMMUNITIES

- »» Faith After Doubt groups
- »» Exvangelical online communities
- »» LGBTQ+ affirming faith spaces
- »» Purity Culture Groups

CLINICIAN RESOURCES

ESSENTIAL READING

- »» Sexual Shame: An Urgent Call to Healing (McClintock, 2001)
- »» Religious and Spiritual Issues in Psychotherapy (Pargament, 2007)
- »» Treating Sexual Shame (Hicks, 2021)
- »» The Body Keeps the Score (van der Kolk, 2014)
- »» Biblical references to sexual immorality often taught (Frick, 2024)

PROFESSIONAL ORGANIZATIONS

- »» APA Division 44 (LGBTQ+ Psychology)
- »» APA Division 43 (Couple & Family)
- »» APA Division 36 (Psychology of Religion)
- »» AASECT (American Assoc. of Sexuality Educators)

TRAINING & CONTINUING EDUCATION

- »» AASECT certification in sex therapy
- »» Religious Trauma Institute clinician training
- »» ICEEFT (EFT) advanced sexuality modules
- »» Sensorimotor Psychotherapy Institute

Barringer, M. N., & Gay, D. A. (2017). Happily religious: The surprising sources of happiness among lesbian, gay, bisexual, and transgender adults. *Sociological Inquiry*, 87(1), 75–96.

Klein, L. K. (2018). *Pure: Inside the evangelical movement that shamed a generation of young women and how I broke free*. Atria Books.

Levine, P. A. (2010). *In an unspoken voice: How the body releases trauma and restores goodness*. North Atlantic Books.

Murray–Swank, N. A., Pargament, K. I., & Mahoney, A. (2005). At the crossroads of sexuality and spirituality. *Counseling and Values*, 49(3), 217–231.

Simon, W., & Gagnon, J. H. (1986). Sexual scripts: Permanence and change. *Archives of Sexual Behavior*, 15(2), 97–120.

Stulhofer, A., & Ajdukovic, D. (2011). Should we take anodyspareunia seriously? *Journal of Sex Research*, 48(4), 346–356.